LEGACY MODEL S AND MODEL X · ABOUT 2012–2020

Phone card for older owners

Screen, keys, 12-volt, doors, air suspension, the rear motor, and FSD. Say it in short sentences.

October 2026 · Built from the faults these cars actually come in for

ASK THIS BEFORE YOU NAME A PART

Year. Whether the screen computer says NVIDIA Tegra or Intel Atom (Controls, then Software, then Additional vehicle information). The words on the screen, exactly. Whether it still drives.

The screen is slow, frozen, or black

On a Tegra car, built before about March 2018, the memory chip behind the screen wears out. That was recall 21V-035. The free repair replaces the chip. It does not turn the car into a newer computer. A paid Intel upgrade is a different job. That upgrade is what adds a usable phone key, Sentry, and a faster screen.

The car can usually still drive. They lose the backup camera, the defrost controls, and the click of the turn signal. Tell them not to install a software update if the screen is already dying. A big update can finish the chip off. To reboot and get home: foot on the brake, hold both scroll wheels until the screen goes black, then let go. If it is black again the next morning, it needs the computer, not another reboot. A screen that still paints a picture but will not answer a finger is often the touch layer, not the memory chip.

Keys

These cars use a fob, not a card. A Tegra car cannot use a phone as the key. An Intel car can. To add a fob they must already have one working key. On the screen: Controls, then Locks, then the key list, then add, then press a button on the new fob when it asks. The wording moved over the years. A cheap fob from the internet often will not pair. If every fob is lost, only Tesla can pair a new one, and they will want proof of ownership.

A fob that works only when held against the door pillar needs a new coin cell, usually a CR2032. If the car suddenly wants a PIN, someone turned on PIN to Drive. A forgotten PIN is not a broken key. Service can clear it with proof they own the car. Do not have them guess.

The small 12-volt battery

This is not the big battery that moves the car. It is often why the screens reboot, the handles stay in, the charge door will not open, and the frunk will not pop. Plan on a few years of life, not ten. If the frunk is shut and the 12-volt is dead, do not send an older owner into the wheel well to hunt for a cable. Send roadside. After a 12-volt replacement on a Model X, the falcon doors often need a calibration. Warn them before the repair so the doors do not scare them at pickup.

Model S door handles

Each handle has its own little motor. One dead handle is not a dead car. Use another door. In ice, do not pull on a handle that will not come out. Forcing it breaks the part. A handle that keeps cycling can run the 12-volt flat. That one is a tow or a mobile visit, not “keep trying it.”

Model X falcon doors

Most “my door is possessed” calls are a block, a low 12-volt, or a lost calibration. Hats, garage rails, and items in the door pocket count as obstacles. Recalibrate from Controls, then Service. If a door stops halfway and will not move, leave it and call. Do not let

them hang on the door.

Air suspension

What they say	Usually	Tell them	On the ticket
One corner is down after it sits	Leak in that air spring	Do not drive it far while it sits on the bump stop.	Which corner, and how fast it drops.
Sinks overnight, all four corners	Compressor, a line, or the dryer	A short drive to service is fine if it will still raise.	Does it raise when they start the car?
Warning, and the car is stuck high	Height sensor, a line, or the compressor	It will feel stiff. Come in slow and straight.	The height it is stuck at.
Unhappy only in a steep driveway	Often normal. It is adjusting.	Give it a minute before you call it broken.	Only if it never levels.
Compressor runs for minutes	It is chasing a leak	Do not keep raising and lowering it to test.	How long the compressor runs.

The control module is not a swap-and-go part. It has to be programmed, and the ride height has to be calibrated. A used module bought online will sit there and do nothing.

Coolant loss, a whine, then an isolation alert

On these years the rear motor can pull coolant in through a seal. The puddle is inside the motor, so they may never see one on the floor. The whine or mill follows road speed. This is the BMS_w172 path. Say “the rear motor is the first suspect,” not “you need a battery.” Do not keep driving it if the coolant is low or the car has already said it may not restart.

Charge door, heat, noises, range

Charge door will not open

Dead 12-volt first, ice second, the latch third. There is a manual release in the trunk liner. If they are unsteady, roadside is safer than a trunk hunt. “Charging is slow” on a cold morning, or on a shared adapter, is often not a broken port. Ask home cord versus Supercharger, and whether the handle gets hot.

No heat

These cars use an electric cabin heater, not a heat pump. The fan can blow and the air can still be cold. That is the heater or its high-voltage supply, not a thermostat. Weak cool air is often a cabin filter that has never been changed, or the compressor. Electric does not mean the filter lasts forever.

Creaks, clunks, headlights

A click on takeoff, once per wheel turn, is often a half shaft. A clunk over bumps can be a lower link or ball joint. A creak from the glass roof in the sun is usually annoying, not dangerous. Pulling, or a wheel that sits off-center after a curb, is an alignment. These cars wear the inner edge of the tires when alignment is off. A headlight that turns yellow or dim on one side is a known aging item, not the big battery.

Range

Some loss after years is normal. A “battery needs service” message, a charge limit stuck near half, or a sudden fall of about 30 miles is not. Do not quote a pack. Quote a test. Codes BMS_a066, a064, and a079 are cell imbalance, not a leak to the body.

The app and the map look dead

Many of these cars shipped with a 3G modem. That network is gone. Remote lock, live location, and streaming maps need the LTE upgrade. The car still drives without it. Bluetooth music still works. Say that before they decide the car has died.

Autopilot and FSD

SAY THIS FIRST

You are still the driver. If the car says take over, you take over. That is the system doing its job, not a breakdown. Dirty glass, low sun, and heavy rain will hand the car back. Wipe the camera at the top of the windshield before we book a visit.

- One camera, Mobileye computer, mostly 2014 through late 2016. This car cannot run today's FSD. No software update changes that. Do not sell hope.
- Later camera cars can be fitted with the HW3 Autopilot computer if the owner bought FSD. A Tegra screen computer is not the computer FSD runs on. Current software wants the Intel screen computer.
- As of October 2026, HW3 cars with Intel screens are starting to get a lighter FSD, v14.3 Lite. It still will not start from Park, will not reverse itself, and does not get the arrival choices the newest cars get.
- HW3 will not do unsupervised driving. Tesla has said people who paid for FSD should get a future computer. Do not give a date.
- A yellow border or bubbles in the glass of the screen is the display aging. That is separate from Autopilot.

Normal, so do not book it

A slight whine that rises with speed. A click as the brakes settle. The suspension adjusting in a steep driveway. Regen that feels weaker when the battery is full or very cold.

TELL THEM TO STOP AND GET A TOW

Smoke. A sharp sweet smell. A battery or isolation warning. The car says it may not restart. A wheel looks tucked up into the arch. A falcon door is stuck in traffic. The steering suddenly goes heavy.

THE TICKET LINE

Their words, plus Tegra or Intel, which door or which corner, coolant loss yes or no, home charge or Supercharger, and the exact sentence on the screen.